for insect infestation. If this occurs, discard all affected material and sterilize the container.

Processing

Herbs can be preserved in a number of ways, the simplest being air or oven drying. A warm, dry place such as an airing cupboard is ideal. Use plain paper for drying herbs, never printed newspaper. Dried herbs can be stored for many months in a dark glass jar or a brown paper bag (*see* p. 288).

Aerial Parts

These include all the parts of the plant growing above ground—stems, leaves, flowers, berries, and seeds. The stems are normally cut 2–4 in (5–10 cm) above ground shortly after the plant has begun to flower, when it is putting most effort into growth. Perennials may be cut higher above ground to encourage further crops. Remove and dry large flowers and leaves separately; smaller ones can be dried on the stem.

- Hang bunches of about 8–10 stems in a warm (but not hot), well-ventilated, dark place. Ensure that the stems and leaves are not too tightly packed together to enable air to circulate freely around them.
- Once brittle but not bone dry, separate small stems, leaves, flowers, and seeds from the stems by rubbing the bunches over a large sheet of plain paper.
- Carefully pour the dried material into a dark glass jar or a brown paper bag.

Large Flowers

In most cases, flowers are picked just after they have opened. Sometimes only specific parts of the flower are used, such as the petals of calendula (*Calendula officinalis*, p. 73), while other flowers are used whole.

- Separate large flower heads from stems and remove any insects or dirt. Place the flowers on absorbent paper on a tray in a dry place, allowing sufficient room between them for air to circulate.
- Once dry, store flower heads in a brown paper bag or dark glass jar. Remove calendula petals from the central part of the flower before storing.

Small Flowers

Small blooms can be picked with the stalk attached and separated later. Hang small flowers, such as lavender (*Lavandula officinalis*, p. 108), upside down in a paper bag, or suspended over a tray (see drying seeds below). If the stems are fleshy, dry as for large flowers, above.

Fruit & Berries

Harvest fruit and berries in early autumn when ripe but still firm. If left to become over-ripe, they may not dry properly. They can be picked individually or in bunches.

- Place berries or fruit on absorbent paper on trays. Put in a warmed oven (turned off) with the door ajar for 3–4 hours. Move to a dry, warm, dark site and turn occasionally. Discard any moldy berries or fruit.

***Brightly colored** petals indicate high levels of active constituents.*

Roots, Rhizomes, Tubers, & Bulbs

The underground parts of the plant are usually gathered in autumn after the aerial parts have withered or become inactive and before the soil is waterlogged or frozen. Many roots may also be collected in early spring before the aerial parts begin to grow. Dig deeply around the root, prying it out of the ground. Some tap roots are difficult to uproot completely. Remove the required amount and replant the remaining root.

- Shake off any soil and wash thoroughly in warm water, removing any small, unwanted side roots or damaged soft spots. Chop into small slices or pieces with a sharp knife.
- Spread out the root pieces on absorbent paper on a tray and place in a warmed oven (turned off) with the door ajar for 2–3 hours. Move to a warm place until dry.

Seeds

Collect ripe seed pods, capsules, or flowering stems in late summer before the seeds have been scattered.

- For tiny seeds, hang small bunches of seedheads upside down over a paper-lined tray, or place in a paper bag. Allow to dry and gently shake. Remove larger seeds by hand when dry.

Sap & Gel

Only harvest sap from your own garden. Collect sap in the spring as it rises, or as it falls in the autumn. Trees such as silver birch (*Betula pendula*, p. 178) produce huge quantities of sap if tapped, although this reduces the tree's vitality. Bore a deep hole into the trunk—no more than a quarter of its diameter—and place a collecting cup under the hole. In spring, quarts of sap may be produced, and it is essential to stop the hole with resin or wood filler after about a quart (liter) of fluid has been removed. Collect milky juices or latex from plants such as dandelion (*Taraxacum officinale*, p. 141) by squeezing the stems over a bowl. Wear gloves, because latex or sap can be corrosive. The gel from aloe vera (*Aloe vera*, p. 60) is scraped out after slicing the leaf lengthwise and peeling back the edges.

Bark

Only harvest bark from your own shrubs or trees as it carries the risk of losing the whole plant through overstripping or "ringing" (removing a whole band of bark). It is best to collect bark from outlying branches, which can then be pruned back. If stripping bark from a plant, gather it in autumn when the sap is falling. Remove insects, lichen, and moss from the bark, cut it into small pieces, and place it on a tray to dry.

Other Ways to Preserve Herbs

Apart from simply air-drying herbs, there are a number of other ways to preserve their medicinal benefits.

Dehumidifying

An effective but expensive way to dry herbs is to use a dehumidifier, which literally sucks water out of the plant. The dehumidifier should be placed in a more or less sealed small room in which the herbs are hung in loose bunches or placed on mesh trays.

Freeze-drying

Freeze-drying retains color and flavor but is more suited to culinary than to medicinal herbs. Whole sprigs of herbs can be frozen in plastic bags. There is no need to defrost before use as the leaves crumble easily when still frozen. Chickweed (*Stellaria media*, p. 272) can also be frozen and used topically for itchy and weeping skin conditions. Many plants may be juiced (*see* p. 297), frozen as ice cubes, and thawed as required.

Microwaving

It is possible to dry herbs in a microwave oven, though this is not recommended. The cut parts should be spread out on kitchen paper and dried in the microwave according to the manufacturer's guidelines.

***A drying rack** for herbs can be simply made by covering a wooden frame with wire mesh.*